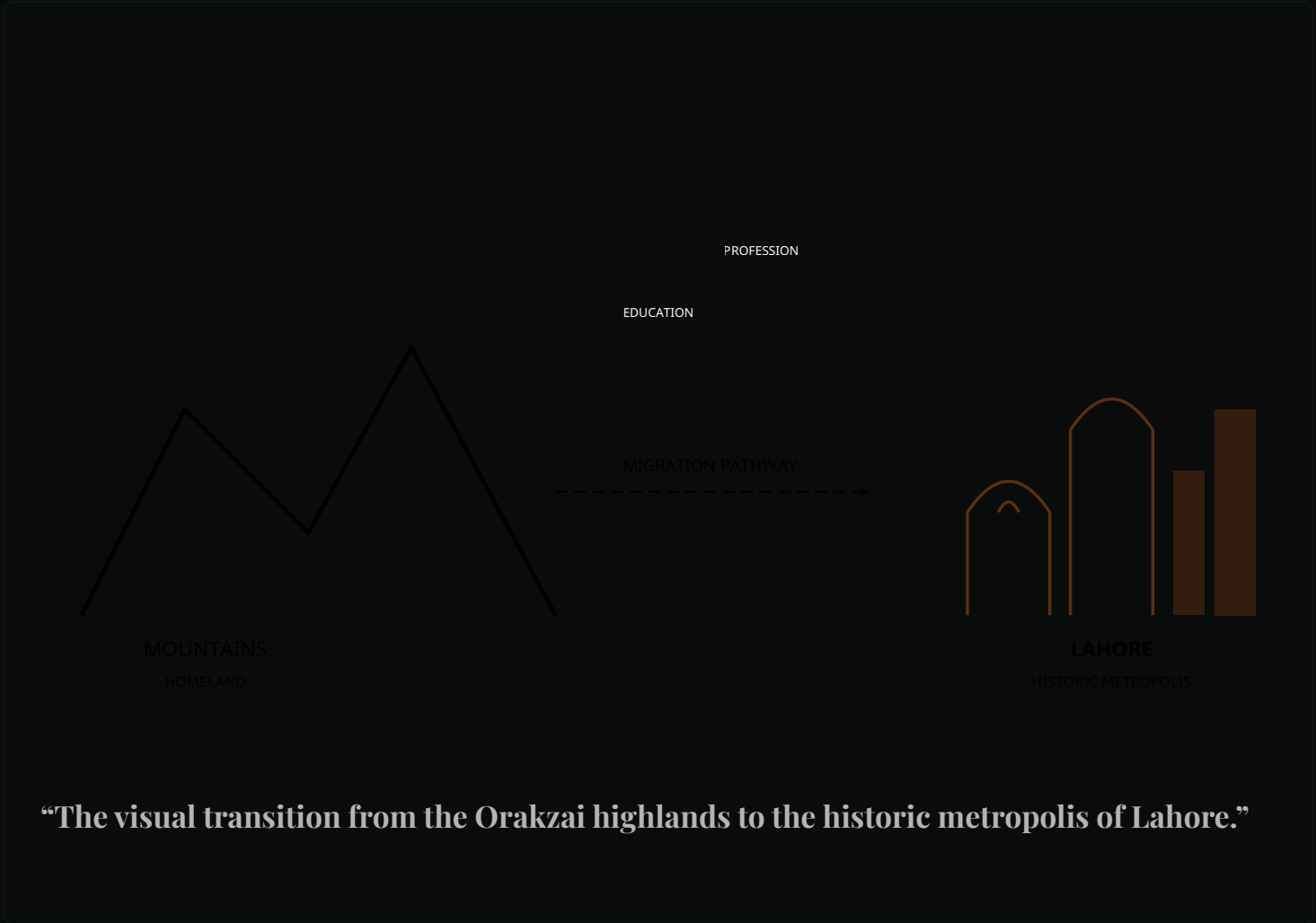


ORAKZAI IN LAHORE

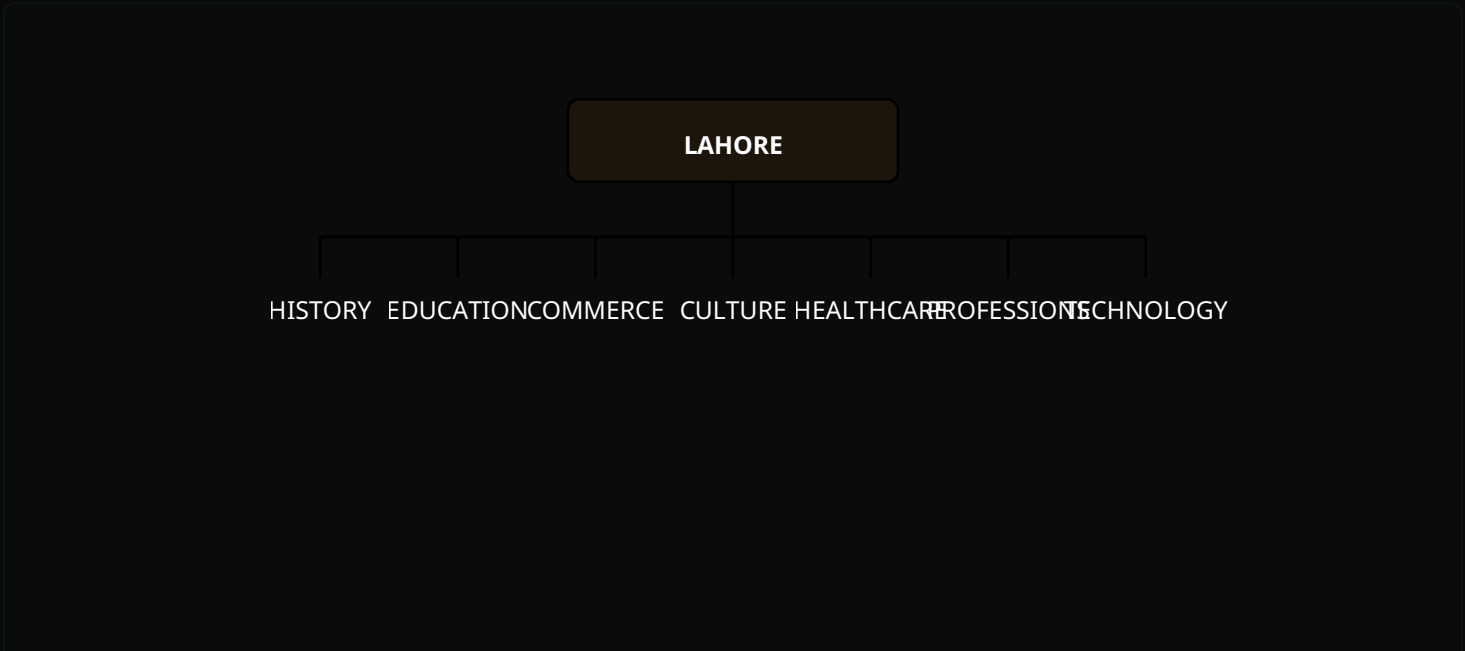
“Carrying homeland memory into a historic metropolis.”

Lahore is another kind of city in the Orakzai story. It is not the homeland. It is not a frontier city. It is not the national capital. Lahore is Punjab's great historic metropolis — a city of universities, markets, hospitals, businesses, literature, food, art and millions of daily journeys. For an Orakzai person, Lahore can represent opportunity at a different scale. A university. A profession. A business. A hospital. A temporary residence. A family home. Or simply a place where life takes a new direction. Yet Lahore is also multilingual. Pashto exists alongside Punjabi, Urdu and English, and migrant families negotiate identity within this changing linguistic environment. For some Orakzai families, therefore, living in Lahore may involve learning how to belong to a new city without forgetting where the family came from. The story is not simply about migration. It is about adaptation. It is about language. It is about family. And it is about carrying memory into a different cultural landscape.



LAHORE AS A METROPOLIS

Lahore is Punjab’s primary metropolitan center, functioning as a provincial capital, educational hub, and commercial powerhouse. Its role as a cultural and healthcare destination attracts individuals from across Pakistan, including the Orakzai community. The city’s diverse sectors—from media and technology to historic commerce—provide a multi-layered urban environment for adaptation and growth.^{2 3}



“The multi-functional roles of Lahore as a historic metropolis.”

LAHORE'S URBAN GROWTH

Academic research documents the rapid urbanization and urban sprawl of Lahore. Between 1990 and 2021, the city's built-up area nearly doubled, expanding from 455 km² to over 807 km². This expansion is driven by rural-to-urban migration and land-use pressures, creating a dynamic metropolitan landscape that continues to attract new residents seeking economic and educational advancement.²

455.45 km²

BUILT-UP AREA (1990)

807.40 km²

BUILT-UP AREA (2021)

SOCIOECONOMIC DETERMINANTS OF MIGRATION

Migration to Lahore is motivated by a combination of economic conditions, employment opportunities, and access to education. Studies indicate that migrants are not only seeking better livelihoods but are also responding to educational deprivation in their home regions. For the Orakzai community, Lahore offers a scale of opportunity that complements the regional hubs of the northwest.³

ORAKZAI

ECONOMIC
CONDITIONS

EMPLOYMENT
SERVICES

EDUCATION

LAHORE

“The socioeconomic drivers of migration to Lahore.”

A 2026 study highlights how migrant Pashto-speaking families in Lahore negotiate their identity through family language policy. In the multilingual context of Lahore, Pashto remains the desired language for home and community communication, while Urdu and English are adopted for utility and social mobility. This linguistic adaptation allows families to belong to the city without losing their ancestral heritage.¹



“The negotiation of identity through family language policy in Lahore (Khalid & Khan, 2026).”

EDUCATION AND PROFESSIONAL PRESENCE

Lahore’s educational ecosystem, including the University of the Punjab, LUMS, and GCU, hosts a verified presence of Orakzai students and alumni. These individuals pursue careers in politics, computer science, mass communication, and entrepreneurship, building professional networks that span the country. Their success stories document the contribution of the Orakzai community to the national professional landscape.⁴

ORAKZAI

UNIVERSITY

PROFESSION

NATIONAL SUCCESS

“The educational and professional pathway of Orakzai individuals in Lahore.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Lahore is the city where the Orakzai spirit meets the history and culture of Punjab. It is a city that demands adaptation—a new language, a different rhythm, a wider horizon. In the lecture halls of the Punjab University or the busy markets of Liberty, I see our people learning how to belong to this great metropolis while remaining anchored to their roots. We are a people who carry our memory with us, even as we build new homes and new careers. Lahore has expanded our world, teaching us that identity is not a fixed point but a living dialogue between where we came from and where we are going. We are Orakzai, and we are at home in the heart of Punjab.

“ANCHORED BY MEMORY, EXPANDED BY THE CITY.”

ORAKZAI IN LAHORE ANALYSIS

